

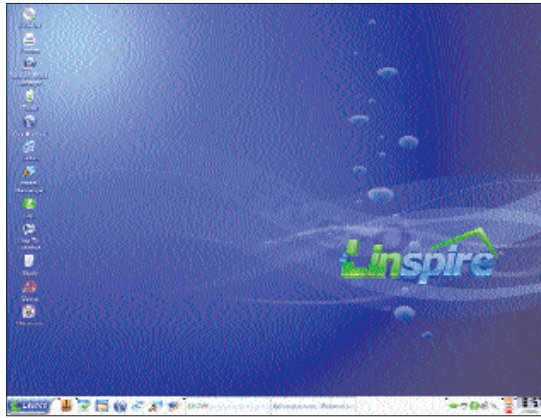
demands a steep learning curve, from the interested and passionate computer user.

This steep learning curve often happens to be the stumbling block, as many first time Linux users struggle to get past doing mundane tasks such as burning CDs, playing music, accessing shares on a network, etc., which otherwise is a no-brainer on a Windows box. Recent developments were largely geared towards reducing this learning curve and make Linux more approachable.

When it comes to using Linux, the biggest challenge a user faces is choosing the right distribution to start with. Speaking of variety, as of today, there are more than a thousand distributions available. Each of these distributions has its unique characteristics—some are totally geared for server use, others are written from scratch for probing network security, while the majority are aimed towards enthusiastic individuals.

If we want to classify distribution based on usage scenarios then there are three broad categories they distinctly address—beginners, power users and corporate.

In distributions aimed at beginners, the focus is often to make the distro look and feel like Windows, so that first time users can gradually learn the new OS without feeling the shift. This makes the transition from other operating systems to Linux much smoother. However, such distri-



Look familiar? That's not Windows; it's Linspire's Interface

butions are made by companies and hence are often paid propositions, as opposed to the basic philosophy of Linux being free.

For power users, being at the cutting edge matters more than simplicity and hence, the focus is often to provide the best there is in the Linux world. Such projects are community-driven and are free to download and use.

Distro's aimed at the corporate world have a different demand; ease of deployment, availability of patches, good technical support and basic sets of applications for office work are some of the important ones corporate users would look for. These projects need dedicated teams and are often a product from a Linux vendor company such as RedHat, SuSe or Mandrake.

In this comparison, we have looked at some of the best distro's

available for the first two categories. For beginners, who want to take the jump in the Linux world, we have Xandros Desktop edition and Linspire 5.0. For power users, we have Fedora core 4, Ubuntu 5.04, SuSe 9.3 professional, RedHat WS, Mandrake 10.1 Power Pack and OpenLx 11.0.

WINDOWS CLONES

To begin with, both Xandros and Linspire (previously known as Lindows) are targeted towards a Linux newbie and are very different from other distros when it comes to general usability. Both distro's offer a sleeker user interface and introduce some excitement into the otherwise bland UI that other Linux distro's have.

Installation

As with Windows, the installation of Linux also requires you to have a bootable CD with you. Both Xandros and Linspire come on a bootable CD and all you need to do is insert the disc in your CD-ROM and wait for the system to boot.

Once the system boots via the CD-ROM, Linspire presents you with a menu to either install it on your hard drive or run it directly from the CD (as a Live CD).

On the other hand, after booting through the CD Xandros directly goes into hardware detection mode and once that is completed, presents a welcome screen.

After you select to install Linspire, the installer goes

How We Tested

Our testing methodology took into account parameters such as ease of installation, ease of use, out of box usability and to some extent hardware support.

In ease of installation, we checked how simple the installation process is? Does it allow you to choose empty space on the hard drive to install the new OS? How simple is the user interface for partitioning the drive? Does the installer provide any useful hints or information during partitioning of the drive? These parameters are quite critical for a beginner and may not be as important to a power user. To gauge the simplicity of installation we got a non-Linux user to install the OS on one of our test machines.

For ease of use, we took into account general usability of the system. To start with we checked how simple it is to customize the system to your liking i.e. wallpapers, screensavers, applying themes, changing fonts and their size, changing the screen resolutions etc. Once the system was set to our liking we moved on to setting up network connection, proxy settings, configuring the email client, configuring a printer. Then we checked sharing of folders on the network, browsing the LAN network, connecting to the Internet, updating the system by downloading new patches, etc. In the process we tried simulating a typical PC usage.

In out of box usability, we looked at the bundled applications and whether they are enough to carry out your daily chores. We looked for an office suite that can be a viable replacement for MS Office, a messenger client for chatting, a good browser for Internet browsing and some sort of image manipulation application. We also tried connecting a USB flash drive and a Digital camera to check the plug and play capability of these distro's. Overall, the idea was to find out how effective Linux distro's are when it comes to real world scenarios.

Right from its inception, hardware support has been a problem with Linux. It is extremely difficult to test distros on every hardware configuration, so we decided to test these distro's on the latest hardware. The idea was that if they work with the latest hardware, chances are that they will work with older hardware as well. Our testbed comprised of an Intel 3.4 GHz Pentium 4, an Intel D875PBZ motherboard, 512 MB DDR RAM, MSI FX 5200 graphics card, Creative Vibra sound card, SATA 400 GB Hitachi hard drive and Samsung's SyncMaster 173P TFT monitor. The other machine was an AMD FX-53 processor, MSI VIA-based motherboard, 1 GB 400 MHz RAM, Gigabyte FX 5950 graphic card, onboard AC97 sound, SATA 120 GB Seagate drive and a Samsung 17-inch CRT monitor.